Necessary Targets

By Eve Ensler

JS: **(Pg 7-10)** *(she speaks as she reviews paperwork)* Your resume's impressive. You come highly recommended. You're trained as a therapist and a writer. That's very unusual.

MELISSA: I am not a therapist. I'm trained as a trauma counselor. I only work with seriously traumatized populations.

MELISSA: Why are you going to Bosnia?

JS: For the President's commission. It's a huge honor. They chose a range of professions for the team. I'm the "shrink" piece. At one time it was my field, trauma.

MELISSA: Yes, eating disorders. I am familiar with your books. *(beat)* You have never been to a war-torn country?

JS: God, no. I mean, Bosnia. . . I read the news, but the Balkans were not next on my vacation map.

MELISSA: War is not exactly the same as anorexia.

JS: I am a psychiatrist. 26 years in private practice. Trauma is trauma.

MELISSA: In Haiti, the psychiatrists were fleeing like flies.

JS: Haiti? Weren't you afraid?

MELISSA: Not in Rwanda, yes . . .

INTRODUCTION

When we think of war, we think of it as something that happens "elsewhere" – never in the United States. It happens to men in fields or jungles with hand grenades and Scud missiles. And we become voyeurs, watching the carnage like it's some reality television show. The bombings, the explosions in the dark that keep us watching. But after the bombing, after the snipers, that's when the real war begins. Because you see, the aftermath of war is just as devastating. It can be found in the broken-down fabric of community, in trauma and depression, poverty and homelessness and starvation. Necessary Targets is a play about women and war -- about the violence of dark memories and the enduring resilience of the human spirit.

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Bosnia. A refugee camp. A barracks-like room. Desolate. Emptiness - a feeling of poverty.

JS: (Pg 16-19) *(enters)* There are big, dirty footprints in the bathroom

MELISSA: Yes, you squat in them

JS: *(appalled)* You mean to . . .

MELISSA: *(laughing)* Poop. Yes, you squat to poop.

JS: *(clearly privileged)* You'll excuse me, but I need the little comforts. I welcome a bath, clean sheet, and a place to sit to . . .

MELISSA: Poop. These women need those same comforts. They had them all before the war.

JS: I don't think squatting in filthy footprints will make me a more effective therapist.

******Scene*******

JELENA: (Pg 29) *(Introducing JS and Melissa to 2 of the refugee women)* This is Seada, the gorgeous one. She is from the country. She never went outside her village before the war. And this is our Zlata, a doctor. You will have a hard time winning Zlata. *(Seada holds out a wrapped little baby and giggles)* Oh, yes. . . and of course, Doona.

ZLATA: (Pg 30-31) What do you want with us?

JS: I have come here . . . well *(looking at Melissa)*, we have come here . . . to help you.

ZLATA: *(sarcastically)* And how do you plan to do that?

MELISSA: We are here to help you, well . . . talk.

ZLATA: There is no shortage of talking here. We are sick of talking.

SEADA: (Pg 47) *(interrupting)* Would you sing to me, Mama?

JS: (Pg 31) We are here to help you talk about the war, about the. . . *(Zlata laughs)*

ZLATA: You flew all the way here for that? Two American doctors to "help" poor Bosnian refugees talk about the war? What did you think we were talking about before you came? Our lingerie, our dinner parties . . .

MELISSA: (Pg 32-35) We are very moved by what you've been through. We were hoping you would tell us your stories.

ZLATA: You and everybody else. They came from everywhere at the beginning of the war to hear the gory details. They left and they never came back.

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MELISSA: Exactly. It is important that people know your stories the way you want to tell them. I am working on a book composed of the stories of refuges all around the world.

ZLATA: Oh, so we're a chapter.

MELISSA: No, no. My writing is not to exploit you. Traumatized war victims . . . Would anyone object to my recording our sessions?

ZLATA: I do not want you recording me.

SEADA: **(Pg 47)** *(it almost seems that she is speaking to Zlata, but she is simply muttering to herself, trapped in her world)* Are you afraid, Mama? Are you afraid too?

*****Scene*****

Barracks room with two cots. J.S. is furiously packing when MELISSA enters.

JS: **(Pg 37-39)** I'm going home. This is ridiculous. Coming to Bosnia to help refugees talk about the war.

MELISSA: I through you were a trained psychiatrist. Trained to see through denial and well-constructed defenses.

JS: *(angry)* Listen. I can't help these women. They need homes, a country, and care. I sense their rightful contempt at being patronized.

MELISSA: I've been in other wars. It always begins like this. These women need an outlet for their rage and despair. We are necessary target.

JS: How does it end?

MELISSA: They tell their stories.

*****Scene*****

Outside the barracks. It is early dawn. ZLATA is sitting on a chair. She has been weeping. She is visibly disturbed. JS enters quietly. She breathes in deeply, then reacts to the rancid smell.

ZLATA: **(Pg 58-59)** Yes, the smells hang. Onion, Old cheese. Garbage. All hanging like a bad mistake.

JS: I am not accustomed to this.

ZLATA: Are you wealthy? *(JS raises her eyebrows, but doesn't respond)* You are wearing a Christian Dior nightgown in a refugee camp. *(shakes her head)* I was rich like you . . . before.

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My parents were very important people. I sleep now in the place of cows. *(JS looks at her meaningfully and nods for her to continue)* Don't. Don't do that psychiatrist thing with me. You only care about the gory details of the story. That's all any of you want.

JS: (Pg 63-65) I want to be your friend.

ZLATA: *(Shaking all over, she speaks with great emotion)* This happened to real people. We were just like you, we weren't ready for this – nothing in our experience prepared us – there were no signs. You want us to be different than you are so you can convince yourselves it wouldn't happen there, where you are. That's why you turn us into stories, into beasts, people who live in a strange country – then you can feel safe, superior. *(She speaks in a mocking superior voice)* "Get us one raped Bosnian woman, preferably gang-raped, preferably English speaking."

JS: I am a doctor, Zlata.

ZLATA: *(broken)* I was a doctor, too, before the war. I was the head of the pediatrics unit in Prijedor's main hospital. Now I stare off at the stars without explanation. I look out at the beet fields and weep for no reason.

*******Scene*******

A new day in the barracks. A Group Session with the refugees)

MELISSA: (Pg 89-91) Where is Seada?

ZLATA: *(dismissively)* Seada's doing fine.

MELISSA: Because she has us – we support her fantasy world, we agree with her delusions. She's living a lie. She's in complete denial. It's killing her.

ZLATA: No, Melissa. What happened to her during the war is killing her. What you call "denial" is keeping her alive.

MELISSA: Barely. She has nightmares almost every night. She's hysterical or wildly depressed most of the time.

ZLATA: Again the assumptions – that we are sick and you know better than us what we need.

MELISSA: (Pg 93) We need to address some basic issues here.

JS: Like what?

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MELISSA: Like what the hell happened to Seada? If we know what happened to Seada, we can help her being to talk about it. We can prepare her for her feelings. Otherwise, she will be consumed by what she refuses to remember . . . *(Melissa turns her recorder on and one of the women, Nuna, begins to speak)*

NUNA: **(Pg 94-97)** Seada lived with her mother and husband. They had a beautiful life in this small village, and a beautiful baby, Doona. Everyone took care of everyone. [But] when the soldiers came . . . They made the people come into the square . . . *(Seada appears outside the group, holding her baby and listening)*

JELENA: Seada was the most beautiful girl in the village. Her husband had heard how the soldiers had been raping the young girls, so they hid Seada in the house.

NUNA: The soldiers found them, though. They tried to take Seada. Her mother and her husband put up a fight and they shot them, both of them, right in the head. Seada saw this happen. She was holding her baby, Doona and she went mad. She started running into the night. The soldiers chased her, but she was running like the wind, for hours without stopping.

JELENA: When you are running crazy like that, You can lose your way.

NUNA: Or . . . your baby. You can lose your baby.

JS: Seada dropped her baby? Oh, my God.

NUNA: She dropped her as she was running.

SEADA: *(Looks down at her bundle of rags and unfolds it. She screams)* Doona! Doona! I have to find Doona! *(She runs out)*

*****Scene*****

Outside. SEADA is on the ground, digging madly at the dirt, pulling her hair, rocking back and forth,

SEADA: **(Pg 102-105)** Mommy! Mommy!

JS: Approaches gently and speaks softly. No, Seada, no Mommy. I'm JS . . . I'm right here.

SEADA: *(wildly anxious, she throws her arms around JS' neck and clings)* No Mommy. No Mommy.

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JS: *(JS wraps her in a calming hug)* It's okay, Seada. I'm right here.

SEADA: Please . . . please help me – help me find my baby. I was a good mother. Help me. *(suddenly mad and panicked)* Those lights, and those voices . . . l loud deep voices laughing, making fun of me. Laughing voices wearing black masks, stinking of shit and meat, tear off my blouse. One spreads my legs and the other holds my arms. *(She intonates in the voice of her rapist)* "We'll show you how to make real babies. We'll fill you with the right kind of babies." And I can hear her suddenly, hear her crying out for her mother. *(wails like her baby)* I cannot get it out of my brain. *(tears at her hair as she continues to wail. JS grabs her and rocks her and Seada gets quiet, confessional)* Mama, I've lost my baby. I've lost our little Doona. *(Silence)*

******* Scene*******

A few days later . . . J.S. sits outside under the stars, clearly disturbed. It is late. ZLATA comes upon her, sits and speaks softly, all sarcasm and bravado gone.

ZLATA: **(Pg 111)** I am impressed. Really. Doctor to doctor. You did good. **(Pg 114-115)** *(JS begins to cry)* What is it?

JS: Nothing. This is not your problem. . . it's the . . .

ZLATA: *(finishes for her)* . . . beauty. Bosnia. Bosnia was beautiful. The snowy mountains, the green green hurt heart of Bosnia. *(she gets lost in her own memory, her story)* The kindness we shared, how we lived in each other's warm kitchens. Gone. The ancient bridges, the mosques, the churches broken now, blown to bits and pieces. It isn't the cruelty that broke my heart. Cruelty is easy. Cruelty, like stupidity, is quick, immediate. They break in, they wear masks, they smell bad, they have machetes, they chop off the heads of my old parents sitting on their couch. There is blood, lots of it. There is screaming. There are dead, headless bodies. We are dead – all of us – to the suffering. There is too much of it – but remind us of the beauty, the beet fields in full bloom, the redness of the fields. Remind us how we once sang, how the voices echoed as one through the landscape of night and stars. Remind us how often we laughed, how safe we felt, how easy it was to be friends. All of us. I miss everything – Bosnia was paradise.

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AWARD HISTORY

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